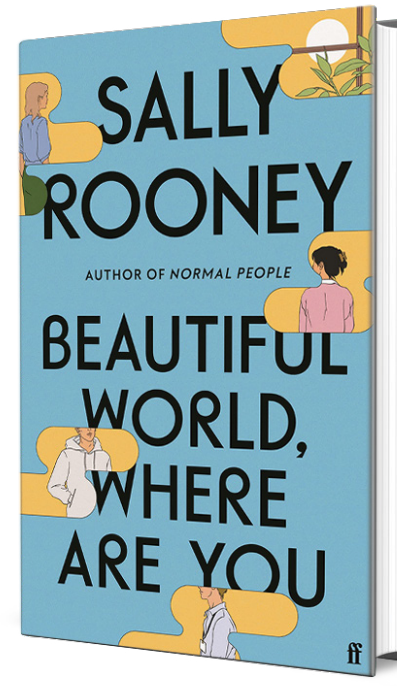
BEAUTIFUL WORLD, WHERE ARE YOU
by Sally Rooney
FABER & FABER
₹699; 352 pages

WE THAT ARE YOUNG



Much like the youth of her characters, **Sally Rooney's** latest novel is caught in a flux of becoming

Sally Rooney is quite the figure of this particular time, a time when authors are also brands, and what they tweet about and look like can often not be set aside while reading their works. This is the affliction of reading Rooney—especially when one of her four central characters, Alice, seems to be based on herself. You see, Alice is a young, attractive woman and a celebrity author and she is grudgingly unhappy about all these things. She has also spent time at a psychiatric facility for what seems like professional burnout.

About half of this novel is epistolary, as Alice maintains email correspondence with her best friend Eileen. Although not exactly "beautiful", their exchanges do have the lanquidness and intellectualisation of youth—the kind of emails you would write at a certain time in your life. "But it also strikes me that the idea of 'conservatism' is in itself false, because nothing can be conserved, as such—time moves in one direction only, I mean. This idea is so basic that when I first thought of it, I felt very brilliant, and then I wondered if I was an idiot," writes Alice. This precise sense of not quite knowing who you are and being in a constant state of becoming has been the hallmark of Brand Rooney.

The other half of this book describes Alice and Eilleen's lives, negotiating their jobs, social expectations and relationships with Felix and Simon, respectively. With the addition of these two outsiders to the women's internal lives and private narratives, Rooney again has her opportunity to explore the criss-crossing gaps between people, society, reality and more. And while *Beautiful World, Where Are You* is an absolutely stellar attempt at doing so—"...we are standing in the last lighted room before the darkness, bearing witness to something..." basically describes an entire zeitgeist in one line—it also seems to have a gap within itself where real feeling should be.

Sally Rooney's *Beautiful World, Where Are You* might be remembered as the transitory novel before she finds her new, true voice

Alice also says at one point, "If novelists wrote honestly about their own lives, no one would read novels." One, at times, wonders if this is Rooney's 'honest' novel, the one where she sheds the brand and is in her own state of becoming something else entirely. The future may remember *Beautiful World, Where Are You* as the transitory novel before Rooney finds her new true voice. This may not be Rooney's best, but it proves her best is yet to come. ■

–Tanushri Shukla